

Minnesota - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Solid bowl-team / top-45 Power Four quality with unusually strong continuity at quarterback, coaching and several offensive anchors, but a 2025 offense that was among the least explosive in FBS and a defense replacing multiple veteran contributors.
Preseason consensus	AP others receiving votes (5 points) · SP+ No. 40
Returning production	68% (No. 8) overall · Off. 71% (No. 10) · Def. 65% (No. 14)
Primer power rating	+6.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.1 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Roughly similar overall: greater offensive continuity creates a path to improvement, while veteran losses in the front and secondary make defensive replication less automatic.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Minnesota keeps its Fleck/Harbaugh pro-style offense around QB Drake Lindsey, RB Darius Taylor and veteran interior OL anchors. EDGE Anthony Smith and LB Maverick Baranowski lead a disruptive defense rebuilding the secondary and interior rotation.

Bottom line: Minnesota has bowl-team continuity, but matching 8-5 requires a major offensive jump from a bottom-tier explosiveness/rushing baseline while defensive and specialist roles reset.

Beats expectations if: QB Drake Lindsey, RB Darius Taylor and the veteran OL turn continuity into efficiency, new WRs add explosiveness, and EDGE Anthony Smith protects the rebuilt secondary with pressure.

Disappoints if: The offense stays non-explosive, RT/TE transitions limit the run/play-action game, and defensive turnover undercuts the SP+ No. 25 projection.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Drake Lindsey is the established returning starting quarterback, giving Minnesota much more preseason certainty than teams still sorting out QB1.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense is the central warning sign: No.129 in total offense, No.128 in rushing and No.135 in explosive-play rate, with success rate No.106.
- 3 ★ EDGE Anthony Smith:** EDGE Anthony Smith is the roster's clearest star-AP and Walter Camp second-team preseason All-American, Big Ten preseason honoree and the anchor of a defense that ranked No.27 in havoc created.
- 4 Returning production:** Returning production is elite nationally at 68% overall (No.8), but the defense still replaces DL Deven Eastern, DB Koi Perich, Za'Quan Bryan, DB Darius Green, Jai'Onte McMillan and other veterans.
- 5 ? Special-teams questions:** Special teams is unusually fluid: SP+ ranks it No.125, Luke Drzewiecki committed after an 18-of-19 FG season but was not yet on the official roster as of Aug. 23, Brady Denaburg's eligibility remains unresolved and no final kicker has been identified.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	8-5 (5-4 Big Ten)	● Good
Scoring	23.0 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	293.2 YPG	● Very poor
Rush offense	103.2 YPG · 3.6 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	6.19 YPA · 19 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	40.1%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	22.9 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	331.6 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	121.1 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	210.5 YPG · 7.40 YPA · 16 TD allowed	● Below average

Minnesota’s offense was among the nation’s weakest in yardage and rushing; the defense was much stronger against the run than the pass.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-1.55 · No. 76	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.020 · No. 75	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	39.6% · No. 106	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	8.1% · No. 135	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	15.7% · No. 84	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.19 · No. 64	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.008 · No. 67	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	43.6% · No. 96	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.2% · No. 73	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	17.5% · No. 27	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: The offense’s problem was structural: No. 106 success rate and No. 135 explosiveness. The defense created havoc at No. 27 but was otherwise more ordinary, so 2026 needs offensive improvement while preserving disruption through turnover.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	P.J. Fleck - returning	● ↔ Program continuity stabilizes a high-returning roster
OC / play caller	Greg Harbaugh Jr. - returning; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Same play-caller and pro-style structure with QB Drake Lindsey
DC / play caller	Danny Collins - returning; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Same caller for a defense strong in havoc and rush defense
Co-DC / CB	Nick Monroe - returning co-DC/cornerbacks	● ↔ Staff continuity, but the secondary is a major rebuild

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Noah Jennings	Cincinnati	● ↔ Major candidate to add needed explosiveness.
♦ WR Perry Thompson	Auburn	● ↔ Adds outside upside to the WR rotation.
♦ TE Kaden Helms	Oklahoma	● ↔ Key TE addition after two veteran departures.
♦ RB Jaron Thomas	Purdue	● ↔ Provides depth behind RB Darius Taylor.

Out	To	Loss
OL Marcellus Marshall / Dylan Ray / Kahlee Tafai	NFL rookie tryouts / transfer	● ↓ Multiple losses heighten the unresolved RT question.
TE Drew Biber / Jameson Geers	NFL signing / minicamp invitation	● ↓ Two veteran tight ends depart.
WR Le'Meke Brockington / Kenric Lanier II	NFL minicamp / transfer	● ↔ Receiving experience leaves a reworked WR room.
RB Cam Davis	College exit; no pro signing established	● ↔ Meaningful backfield contributor is absent; departure mechanism remains unresolved.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Core QB/RB/OL anchors return, but OL/TE/WR turnover leaves the explosiveness fix unproven.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ DB Aydan West	Michigan State	● ↔ Front-runner for an open corner job.
♦ DL Naquan Crowder	Marshall	● ↔ Leading interior option after DL attrition.
♦ DL TJ Bush Jr.	California	● ↔ Adds needed front depth.
♦ LB Andrew Marshall	Eastern Michigan	● ↔ Competes for the open LB job beside LB Maverick Baranowski.

Out	To	Loss
DL Deven Eastern	NFL (Seattle), Round 7, No. 242	● ↓ Thirteen-game starter leaves the front.
DB Koi Perich	Oregon	● ↓ Major secondary departure.
CB Za'Quan Bryan	South Florida	● ↓ Starting corner leaves.
DB Darius Green / Jai'Onte McMillan	College exits; no destination established	● ↔ Two veteran DBs are absent; departure status remains unresolved.
DL Jalen Logan-Redding / Rushawn Lawrence	College exits; no destination established	● ↔ Interior experience is absent; departure status remains unresolved.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Secondary/interior continuity drops, though EDGE Anthony Smith, LB Maverick Baranowski and transfers preserve a credible floor.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Pro-style under-center run/play-action/RPO attack with QB Drake Lindsey.	QB/staff continuity, RB Darius Taylor and two OL anchors.	Continuity must fix No. 128 rushing and No. 135 explosiveness.
Defense	Same play-caller with an edge-driven front led by EDGE Anthony Smith.	EDGE Anthony Smith, LB Maverick Baranowski and No. 27 rush defense.	No. 96 success-rate defense plus major secondary/front turnover.
Special teams	Open kicker and punter competitions.	K Luke Drzewiecki brings strong 2025 results if added to the roster.	SP+ No. 125; K Brady Denaburg eligibility and both jobs remain unresolved.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↑	High	QB Drake Lindsey is an established second-year starter with improved command.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Darius Taylor is the clear high-end lead back with useful depth.
WR	● C+	● ↑	Medium	Returning starters plus WR Noah Jennings/WR Perry Thompson must lift No. 135 explosiveness.
TE	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	Two veteran TEs depart; TE Kaden Helms leads the replacement group.
OL	● B	● ↔	Medium	OL Greg Johnson/C Ashton Beers anchor the line; RT remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	EDGE Anthony Smith is elite, but veteran front departures reduce continuity.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	LB Maverick Baranowski is locked in; the second job remains open.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	S Kerry Brown/DB John Nestor anchor a secondary replacing multiple veterans.
Special teams	● C–	● ↓	Low	SP+ No. 125 with unresolved kicker eligibility/roster status and punter competition.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	HC P.J. Fleck and both play-callers return.
Overall	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	Top-45 profile: strong continuity versus a poor offensive baseline and defensive/specialist turnover.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Anthony Smith	EDGE	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP second-team All-America · Walter Camp second-team All-America · Big Ten preseason honoree · Bednarik · Walter Camp POY	Elite front anchor through major defensive turnover.
Darius Taylor	RB	● High-end conference starter	Maxwell	Proven centerpiece for improving the No. 128 rushing baseline.
Drake Lindsey	QB	● Established returning starter	-	Second-year starter central to converting continuity into production.
★ Greg Johnson	OL	● Nationally recognized OL anchor	AP second-team All-America · Outland	Premier returning anchor for a changing line.
Ashton Beers	C	● High-end returning center	Rimington	Interior continuity while RT remains open.
Maverick Baranowski	LB	● High-end returning starter	Butkus	Locked starter beside an open second LB job.
Noah Jennings (TR: Cincinnati)	WR	● Transfer breakout candidate	-	Needed upside for a passing game short on explosives.
Kerry Brown	S	● Secondary anchor	-	Critical continuity after extensive DB turnover.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Challenging but navigable: three favorable home games precede a much harder Big Ten slate.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 31
Hardest stretch	Iowa → at Indiana → UCLA → at Penn State
Swing games	Mississippi State, at Purdue, UCLA, Northwestern, at Wisconsin
Advantage	Three straight home games open the year; the Oct. 17 bye precedes the hardest run.
Expected	6.1 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Continuity is attractive, but the 8-5 record overstates a weak underlying offense. Price Minnesota as solid, not automatically improved.
Back them when	RB Darius Taylor/interior OL can control early downs and EDGE Anthony Smith can pressure without requiring an unproven explosiveness jump.
Fade/pass when	Opponents force obvious passing downs or the price ignores RT, secondary and special-teams uncertainty.
Key monitor	Offensive explosiveness, RT/Bennett Warren, second LB, corner/safety jobs, K Luke Drzewiecki/K Brady Denaburg status, punter
Week 1 baseline	vs. Eastern Illinois: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Minnesota –43.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Minnesota’s case starts with continuity: QB Drake Lindsey, RB Darius Taylor, two OL anchors and both play-callers return. That gives a historically unproductive, non-explosive offense a plausible path to become merely functional - enough to matter if the defense holds.

EDGE Anthony Smith and LB Maverick Baranowski give the defense a strong spine, but secondary/front turnover and unsettled specialists add risk. Against SOS No. 31, **6.1 wins and 6-6** is the appropriate baseline until the offense proves a real jump.

About this primer

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